

THE RHYTHM PLAYBOOK

3 Go-To Rhythm Patterns for Groove and Feel



Introduction from Adam

These three rhythm patterns are my go-tos when I want to bring a simple chord progression to life. They're easy to learn, super versatile, and instantly add groove and forward motion to your playing.

Lean On Me - Bill Withers

Chord Progression

👉 To listen to Bill Withers acapella - [Click Here](#)

🕒 video 0:51

The musical notation shows the chord progression for 'Lean On Me' in 4/4 time. The first system consists of four measures: C, F, C, and a half-measure split between Em/G and G, followed by a half-measure for F/G. The second system consists of two measures: C and G7, followed by a half-measure split between C and C.

This is the chord progression from Lean On Me, played as **simple, sustained chords** — just solid blocks of harmony with no added rhythm. It gives us a clear foundation to work from, so you can really hear how much the groove transforms the feel once we start introducing the patterns.

Rhythm Pattern #1

The Toggle



video 2:00

The Toggle divides your right hand into two parts — the thumb and the upper fingers — and alternates between them. This simple back-and-forth motion fills the bar and creates that sense of **movement** that makes the groove feel alive.

The musical notation for 'The Toggle' is presented in two systems. Each system consists of a treble and bass staff. The first system contains four measures with the following chords: C, F, C, and a sequence of Em/G, G, F/G. The second system also contains four measures with the following chords: C, F, C, and a sequence of G7, C. The right hand plays a steady eighth-note pattern, while the left hand plays a simple bass line with eighth and quarter notes.

This pattern can feel a little tricky at first because your hands aren't landing together in the usual way. Take it slowly, listen for the conversation between the hands, and let the groove settle in naturally — that interplay is what really brings it to life.

Rhythm Pattern #2

The Push In The Middle



video 4:14

The Push in the Middle places a subtle accent on the end of beat two, giving the bar a gentle lift forward. It's a super versatile accompaniment pattern that instantly adds **momentum** and a soulful sense of groove.

The musical notation shows two systems of piano accompaniment in 4/4 time. The first system consists of four measures with chords C, F, C, and Em/G, G, F/G. The second system consists of four measures with chords C, F, C, and G7, C. An orange arrow points to the end of the second measure in the first system, labeled "push".

This one can feel unusual at first because the push doesn't land on a strong beat. Try counting steadily and even saying **"push"** out loud as you practise — once your ear locks into that subdivision, the rhythm will start to feel completely natural.

Rhythm Pattern #3

The Woodchop



video 6:15

The Woodchop locks into every subdivision in the right hand, creating a steady, driving pulse. It's repetitive in the best way — that constant motion is what keeps the music moving forward.

The key here is **staying relaxed** while you maintain the subdivision all the way through. It can feel busy at first, but once you settle into the groove and let the left hand support it, the pattern becomes surprisingly satisfying to play.



Wrapping Up from Adam

Now it's your turn—experiment with these patterns, mix them together, and see how rhythm can completely transform a simple progression.

If you have any questions or feedback, feel free to email me at adam@thekeyscorch.com